

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS, INC.

FIRST PLANNING MEETING GUIDE

For a Newly Commissioned Lodge

PURPOSE

The first planning meeting brings the commissioned organizers together to begin establishing the Lodge.

Because permanent officers have not yet been selected, the meeting is scheduled and led by the commissioned organizer or organizing committee.

The meeting should:

- Review the Lodge Commission.
- Confirm the organizing members.
- Discuss the Lodge's purpose and identity.
- Explain the offices that must eventually be filled.
- Establish a process and timeline for selecting officers.
- Begin work on Lodge by-laws.
- Assign administrative and organizational tasks.
- Establish communication and record-keeping systems.
- Schedule the next planning meeting.

The goal is not to complete every task. The goal is to establish an organized path from commission to regular Lodge operation.

I. RESPONSIBILITY OF THE ORGANIZER

Until officers are properly selected, the organizer or organizing committee is responsible for:

- Scheduling planning meetings.
- Providing notice to organizing members.
- Preparing the agenda.
- Securing a meeting location.
- Leading discussions.
- Maintaining order.
- Ensuring decisions are recorded.
- Assigning temporary organizational work.
- Communicating with the Grand Lodge or United Council.

- Coordinating the officer-selection process.
- Scheduling the next meeting.

The organizer's authority is temporary. Serving as organizer does not automatically make a person the Worthy Master or another Lodge officer.

II. BEFORE THE MEETING

Suggested Length

The meeting should last approximately **90 minutes**.

Participants

Invite:

- The commissioned organizer or organizers.
- All persons named in the Lodge Commission.
- Other approved organizing members.
- A Grand Lodge or United Council mentor, when available.

Meeting Notice

The organizer should provide:

- Date, time, and location.
- Purpose of the meeting.
- Proposed agenda.
- Documents to review.
- Any materials members should bring.

Although this is an organizational meeting rather than a regular Lodge meeting, members should receive reasonable notice and an agenda in advance. Regular Lodge standards call for advance notice and distribution of meeting materials before the meeting.

Suggested Materials

Prepare:

- Lodge Commission.
- Attendance sheet.
- Organizing-member contact list.
- AOFG Constitution and By-Laws.
- Grand Lodge By-Laws, if applicable.
- Approved Lodge by-laws template.
- Lodge Leadership Guide.

- Opening Your Lodge guide.
- Lodge logo instructions.
- Action-assignment sheet.
- Meeting-record template.

III. TEMPORARY MEETING ROLES

Temporary Chair

The commissioned organizer normally serves as Temporary Chair and:

- Calls the meeting to order.
- Presents the agenda.
- Recognizes speakers.
- Keeps discussion focused.
- Calls for decisions when necessary.
- Reviews assignments before closing.

Temporary Recorder

The members should select a Temporary Recorder to:

- Record attendance.
- Record decisions and assignments.
- Note unresolved questions.
- Prepare the written meeting record.
- Preserve documents for the future Lodge Secretary.

Serving as Temporary Recorder does not automatically make the person the permanent Secretary.

A timekeeper may also be selected to help keep the meeting within the scheduled time.

IV. RECOMMENDED AGENDA

1. Call to Order

5 minutes

Suggested wording:

Members and organizers of the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, we have assembled for the first planning meeting of this newly commissioned Lodge. Our purpose is to establish an organized foundation, prepare for the selection of officers, and begin the work necessary for regular Lodge operation and future chartering.

The Temporary Recorder notes:

- Date.
- Time.
- Location.
- Persons present.
- Temporary Chair.
- Temporary Recorder.

2. Opening Reflection

5 minutes

The organizer may invite a member to offer a brief invocation or reflection on growth, wisdom, fellowship, service, or responsibility.

Because no Chaplain has been selected, this is a temporary assignment for the meeting.

3. Introductions

10 minutes

Each organizer should briefly state:

- Their name.
- Why they are interested in the Lodge.
- A skill or experience they can contribute.
- One hope they have for the Lodge.

This helps identify the strengths of the organizing group without prematurely assigning officers.

4. Review of the Lodge Commission

10 minutes

Read or present the Lodge Commission and confirm:

- Official Lodge name.
- Lodge number.
- Date of commission.
- Jurisdiction.
- Names of commissioned organizers.
- Sponsoring Grand Lodge, if applicable.
- Relationship to the United Council.
- Any requirements or deadlines.
- Conditions that must be completed before chartering.

The Commission should be preserved as part of the Lodge's permanent records.

5. Purpose and Vision of the Lodge

10 minutes

Discuss the purpose and intended character of the Lodge.

The Opening Your Lodge guide encourages members to study the Order's history, ceremonies, symbols, and meeting traditions. It also recommends discussion of metaphorical gardening through sowing ideas, pruning harmful habits, and harvesting wisdom.

Suggested questions:

- What should this Lodge contribute to its members?
- What needs should it address in the community?
- What kind of fellowship should it provide?
- What positive ideas should it sow?
- What habits should members help one another prune?
- What wisdom or service should the Lodge eventually harvest?

The Temporary Recorder should prepare a short summary of the Lodge's emerging vision.

6. Review of the Organizing Process

5 minutes

Explain the general path from commission to charter:

1. Organize the commissioned members.
2. Review the governing documents.
3. Draft Lodge-specific by-laws.
4. Establish the officer-selection process.
5. Select and train officers.
6. Establish records and financial procedures.
7. Secure a regular meeting location.
8. Begin regular meetings and programs.
9. Admit and instruct members properly.
10. Maintain reports and demonstrate stability.

The Opening Your Lodge guide identifies by-laws, legal organization, finances, meeting space, recruitment, programming, communication, and record keeping as important parts of establishing a Lodge.

7. Review of Future Lodge Offices

15 minutes

The organizer should briefly explain the Lodge offices.

Worthy Master

- Presides over meetings.
- Maintains order.
- Represents the Lodge.
- Ensures compliance with governing documents and ceremonial standards.

Emissary Master

- Assists the Worthy Master.
- Presides in the Worthy Master's absence.
- Represents the Lodge during visitations.

Secretary

- Maintains correspondence.
- Prepares agendas.
- Records minutes.
- Maintains membership and administrative records.
- Submits required reports.

Rentmaster

- Safeguards Lodge funds.
- Maintains financial records.
- Presents financial reports.
- Assists with budgeting and fundraising.

Instruction Master

- Trains officers and members.
- Promotes accuracy in ceremonial work.
- Conducts instruction and rehearsals.

Chaplain

- Provides spiritual and moral support.
- Offers invocations and benedictions.
- Assists members during hardship or bereavement.

Gatekeeper and Keyholder

- Protect the privacy and security of the Lodge.
- Control access.
- Assist with room preparation, visitors, and regalia.

These duties are described in the Lodge Leadership Guide.

This discussion is for education only. No member should be assumed to hold an office until the approved selection process is completed.

8. Officer-Selection Process

10 minutes

The organizers should determine how and when officers will be selected according to the AOFG Constitution and By-Laws, applicable Grand Lodge rules, and the Commission.

Discuss:

- Eligibility to hold office.
- Eligibility to vote.
- Whether officers are elected or appointed.
- Nomination procedures.
- Whether voting will be open or by secret ballot.
- Length of the first officer terms.
- When officers will assume their duties.
- Whether installation or approval is required.

Before ending this item, establish:

- Date of the officer-selection meeting.
- Deadline for nominations.
- Person responsible for preparing the process.
- Any questions that must be referred to the Grand Lodge or United Council.

Members should have time to review the duties before accepting nominations.

9. Temporary Organizational Assignments

10 minutes

Temporary work assignments may be made until officers are selected.

Possible assignments include:

- Records Coordinator.
- Communications Coordinator.
- By-Laws Coordinator.
- Meeting-Location Coordinator.
- Finance Research Coordinator.
- Logo Coordinator.
- Membership Information Coordinator.
- Program Planning Coordinator.

These are temporary responsibilities, not Lodge offices.

Each assignment should include:

- The task.
- The person responsible.
- The deadline.
- The expected report.
- Any limits on spending or decision-making.

10. By-Laws Planning

10 minutes

The organizers should begin reviewing the approved Lodge by-laws template.

The Opening Your Lodge guide requires a new Lodge to use the approved template and add Lodge-specific information required by the Council or adopted by the Lodge.

Information to complete may include:

- Lodge name and number.
- Regular meeting schedule.
- Meeting location.
- Membership requirements.
- Dues and fees.
- Officer selection and terms.
- Quorum.
- Committees.
- Financial procedures.
- Amendment procedures.

Determine:

- Who will serve on the temporary By-Laws Work Group.
- When the first draft is due.
- When the organizers will review it.
- Whether approval from the Grand Lodge or United Council is required.

No local provision may conflict with the superior governing documents.

11. Lodge Identity and Logo

5 minutes

Confirm the official Lodge name and number exactly as shown on the Commission.

Discuss the meaning of the Lodge name and its relationship to:

- Local flora.
- Local history.
- The natural environment.
- The teachings of Free Gardening.
- The intended character of the Lodge.

The Lodge logo must be dignified and faithful to the Order. It should include the name of the Order or A.O.F.G., the Lodge name and number, and approved traditional symbols such as the square, compass, pruning knife, or the letters A S N O in their proper arrangement.

Local imagery may be included but should not replace or overshadow the traditional symbols.

Assign someone to prepare logo concepts for a later meeting. A final design does not need to be adopted at the first meeting.

12. Communication and Records

10 minutes

Establish temporary systems for:

- Official Lodge email.
- Private organizing-group communication.
- Member contact list.
- Shared calendar.
- Secure digital document folder.
- Meeting records.

The Opening Your Lodge guide recommends Lodge email, social media where appropriate, private communication channels, regular planning meetings, and distribution of concise meeting records.

Temporary records should include:

- Commission.
- Organizing-member list.
- Meeting notices.
- Meeting records.
- Assignments.
- Correspondence.
- By-laws drafts.
- Officer-selection documents.
- Financial research.
- Venue information.

The Lodge Leadership Guide requires accurate administrative, ceremonial, membership, committee, and financial records.

These records should later be transferred to the selected Secretary.

13. Legal, Financial, and Meeting-Space Research

10 minutes

Assign members to research:

- State or local registration requirements.
- EIN requirements.
- Banking requirements.
- Insurance.
- Initial expenses.
- Possible dues and fees.
- Meeting locations.

The approved legal naming format is:

Ancient Order of Free Gardeners – [Lodge Name and Number]

The legal name should not use a number sign or abbreviation.

No organizer should:

- Place Lodge funds in a personal account.
- Sign a long-term agreement without authorization.
- Incur major expenses without group approval.
- Claim legal status before registration is complete.

Possible meeting locations should provide privacy, security, accessibility, reasonable cost, and sufficient space for future ceremonies. The organizing guide calls for a regular secure meeting space.

14. Preliminary Calendar and Membership Planning

10 minutes

Prepare a simple three- to six-month calendar that may include:

- Second planning meeting.
- Officer-selection meeting.
- Officer training.
- By-laws review.
- Ceremony rehearsal.
- Inaugural Lodge meeting.

- Membership information session.
- Community service.
- Fellowship activity.
- Educational program.
- Quarterly growth review.

The Opening Your Lodge guide recommends service projects, social activities, lectures, ceremony rehearsals, leadership training, workshops, and quarterly reviews.

The organizers should also decide who will temporarily answer membership inquiries.

Formal applications should not be approved until the Lodge has established its by-laws, officers, and approved membership process unless otherwise authorized.

The Leadership Guide describes the regular process as inquiry, application, interview, Lodge review, vote, approval, ceremony, and completion of the Admission Record.

V. ACTION ASSIGNMENT SHEET

Before closing, the Temporary Recorder should review all assignments.

Action Item	Person Responsible	Deadline
Prepare meeting record		
Create organizing-member contact list		
Establish Lodge email		
Establish private communication group		
Review officer-selection requirements		
Contact Grand Lodge or United Council		
Prepare nomination or election procedure		
Begin by-laws draft		
Research meeting locations		
Research registration and EIN requirements		
Research banking requirements		
Prepare preliminary expense estimate		
Prepare logo concepts		
Draft preliminary calendar		
Schedule next meeting	Organizer	

Every assignment should have one primary person responsible and a clear deadline.

VI. CLOSING THE MEETING

Before adjournment, confirm:

- Decisions made.
- Assignments and deadlines.
- Questions requiring outside guidance.
- Date, time, and location of the next meeting.
- Documents or reports due at the next meeting.
- Whether nominations will be accepted before or during the next meeting.

Suggested closing wording:

Today we have begun the work of organizing this Lodge. The Commission gives us authority to begin, but careful planning, shared responsibility, and faithful service will determine what we build. Let each organizer complete the work accepted today so that the Lodge may soon be prepared to select its officers and begin its regular labor.

The Temporary Recorder notes the time of adjournment.

VII. AFTER THE MEETING

Within three business days, the organizer and Temporary Recorder should:

- Prepare and distribute the meeting record.
- Distribute the action-assignment list.
- Confirm deadlines.
- Update the contact list.
- Preserve the Commission and organizational documents.
- Send unresolved questions to the proper authority.
- Confirm the next meeting.

The record should clearly state that:

- The meeting was led by the organizer.
- Permanent Lodge officers had not yet been selected.
- Temporary roles were not permanent appointments.
- Organizational assignments were temporary.
- Officers will be selected through the approved process.

VIII. RECOMMENDED NEXT STEPS

Second Planning Meeting

- Review completed assignments.
- Review the by-laws draft.
- Confirm officer eligibility and selection procedures.
- Receive nominations when appropriate.
- Review meeting-location options.
- Review legal and financial research.
- Confirm the officer-selection meeting.

Officer-Selection Meeting

- Confirm eligible voters.
- Receive or close nominations.
- Conduct elections or appointments.
- Record the results.
- Schedule officer training and installation.
- Establish the date officers assume responsibility.

First Meeting After Officer Selection

- Transfer temporary records.
- Review officer duties.
- Establish regular meeting procedures.
- Approve financial controls.
- Establish committees.
- Prepare for the inaugural Lodge meeting.

IX. FIRST-MEETING CHECKLIST

At adjournment, the organizers should be able to answer yes to the following:

- Was the meeting led by the commissioned organizer?
- Was a Temporary Recorder selected?
- Was the Commission reviewed?
- Were the organizing members identified?
- Was the Lodge's purpose discussed?
- Were the future offices explained?
- Was an officer-selection timeline established?
- Were temporary assignments made?
- Was the by-laws process started?

- Were communication and record systems established?
- Were legal, financial, and venue research tasks assigned?
- Was a preliminary calendar discussed?
- Was the next meeting scheduled?
- Were all assignments given deadlines?
- Was it clearly recorded that no permanent officers had been selected?

A successful first planning meeting should conclude with clear responsibilities, practical deadlines, and an organized path toward selecting officers and beginning regular Lodge work.